

Final Investigative Report: The Liberty County Corruption Nexus

DATE: September 9, 2025

SUBJECT: Analysis of Alleged Systemic Corruption, Nepotism, and Predatory Land Practices in Liberty County, Texas.

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Executive Summary

This report details a web of alleged corruption, conflicts of interest, and systemic malfeasance in Liberty County, Texas, with the **Colony Ridge** development at its epicenter. Investigative data, financial records, and official documents reveal a pattern of self-dealing orchestrated by an insular network of public officials, developers, attorneys, and their affiliates. This network appears to leverage legislative actions, Municipal Utility Districts (MUDs), political donations, and familial connections to profit from unregulated development, externalizing costs onto taxpayers and consumers while privatizing profits.

The operational model, as alleged in federal and state lawsuits, involves predatory "bait-and-switch" land sales targeting vulnerable, often Hispanic, homebuyers. This has led to an abnormally high foreclosure rate, feeding a lucrative cycle of property resale ¹. The complex network of financial, political, legal, and familial conflicts of interest detailed herein warrants a formal external investigation for potential violations of state and federal law, including **Abuse of Official Capacity, Bribery, Nepotism, and Mail/Wire Fraud**.

I. Legislative Framework: Engineering an Environment for Exploitation

The rapid, unchecked growth of Colony Ridge was enabled by a series of state-level legislative actions. These bills, sponsored by legislators with documented ties to the real estate, development, and engineering industries, created a permissive environment for developer-controlled special districts—granting them significant public powers while simultaneously eroding local democratic oversight.

Bill	Sponsor(s)	Core Change	Damaging Impact
HB 4341 (2017)	Rep. Ernest Bailes; Sen. Robert Nichols	Created Liberty County Municipal Management District No. 1 (added Chapter 3795 to Special District Laws Code)	Transformed a public entity into a private instrument. Granted the developer power to issue bonds and annex its own land, creating a foundational conflict of interest.

Bill	Sponsor(s)	Core Change	Damaging Impact
Opportunity Zone (2018)	Gov. Greg Abbott	Designated Colony Ridge area census tracts as a federal Opportunity Zone	Enabled lucrative tax-sheltered investments for the development; designation came shortly after ~\$1.4 M in developer campaign donations ² , facilitating major outside investor inflows.
HB 4370 (2025)	Rep. Will Metcalf; Rep. Cecil Bell Jr.; Sen. César Blanco (co-sponsor)	Expanded allowable projects that MUDs can finance (including certain energy infrastructure)	Opened new bond-financing pathways favoring specific vendors and developers; increased debt exposure for residents via broader MUD spending authority.
SB 2419 (2025)	Sen. Angela Paxton; Rep. Jay Dean	Allowed special districts to retain powers after city disannexation	Insulated developer-controlled districts from municipal oversight; prevented nearby cities from regaining regulatory control, reducing residents' recourse.
SB 1566 (2025)	Sen. Paul Bettencourt	Allowed CCN (utility) holders to bypass city plat approval for new service areas	Accelerated unregulated growth by removing a key layer of municipal oversight on developments; weakened checks that typically ensure infrastructure keeps pace.
HB 447 (2025)	Rep. Keith Bell	Required traffic impact studies for MUD-built roads, but allowed county commissioners to waive the requirement	Created a loophole for large-scale rural subdivisions to proceed without adequate road infrastructure planning; favored the developer's pace of expansion over public safety.
HB 2715 (2025)	Rep. Pat Curry; Rep. David Cook; Sen. Mayes Middleton	Transferred certain local official removal proceedings to out-of-region judges	Shielded compromised local power structures by moving cases away from local scrutiny; could be used to protect pro-developer officials from community-led removal efforts.

Link to Colony Ridge / Consumer Harm: *Collectively, these bills and policy actions dismantled traditional oversight, empowered developer-run districts, and transferred infrastructure and debt risks onto consumers and taxpayers. This legal scaffolding enabled Colony Ridge's operators to pursue high-volume land sales and heavy MUD/MMD bond financing while bypassing the normal checks that protect homeowners and local governments.*

II. Subdivisions by Special District (Consolidated)

Colony Ridge’s expanse is organized into numerous platted subdivisions, which fall under several special-purpose districts created to finance and manage infrastructure. The following tables consolidate known information about how subdivisions align with each **Municipal Management District (MMD)** or **Municipal Utility District (MUD)**, along with recorded plat data. (Many of these districts remain under developer control until sufficient residents move in, enabling direct self-dealing in the interim. For example, **Liberty County MMD #1**’s 2024 audit shows the district owes \$15.4 million to the developer, and its board—led by developer affiliates—approved \$22.5 million in contracts to a paving company linked to the developer ³ ⁴ . Likewise, the creation of **MUD #15** was approved in a 2025 election with only two total voters, yet authorized **\$88 million** in bond debt ⁵ .)

District → Subdivision Alignment

Special District	Year Created	Representative Subdivisions Covered	Notes
Liberty County MMD No. 1 (Mgmt. District)	2017 (via HB 4341)	<i>Santa Fe</i> Sec. 15 (confirmed); overlay encompasses large portions of <i>Santa Fe</i> , <i>Grand San Jacinto</i> , <i>Montebello</i> , <i>Bella Vista</i> , <i>Rancho San Vicente</i> , and <i>Camino Real</i> commercial corridors	Governs Colony Ridge’s special sales-tax zone; board approved \$22.5M in contracts to developer-affiliated firm (Liberty Paving); tightly controlled by developer’s insiders.
Liberty County MUD No. 6	2009 (via SB 2524)	Early sections of <i>Santa Fe</i> (Secs. 1–3) and <i>Grand San Jacinto</i> ; legacy tracts near Plum Grove	First utility district serving Colony Ridge area; issued initial water/sewer bonds. Developer-appointed board at inception.
Liberty County MUD No. 12	2023 (via SB 2580)	Newer sections of <i>Camino Real</i> (east side) and <i>Santa Fe</i> (Secs. 9–12); portions of <i>Rancho San Vicente</i>	Created via Rep. Bailes/Sen. Nichols legislation; authorized up to \$175M in bonds. All initial directors appointed by developer until residents accrue.
Liberty County MUD No. 15	2025 (TCEQ pet. confirmed May 2025)	Planned expansion areas northeast of <i>Santa Fe</i> (Sec. 13+); new <i>Tarkington</i> area tracts east of <i>Grand San Jacinto</i>	Authorized \$88M in bonds by a 2-voter election ⁵ ; developer-appointed board illustrates extreme manipulation of the MUD creation process.

Special District	Year Created	Representative Subdivisions Covered	Notes
Liberty County MUD No. 1 (original numbering)	2017 (TCEQ creation)	Scattered parcels overlapping Colony Ridge expansion corridors (exact sections TBD)	<i>Not to be confused with MMD #1. One of several utility MUDs established as Colony Ridge grew; created for utility service and bond flexibility (details pending official plat mapping).</i>

(Additional MUDs #2–#14 also exist or are planned in Liberty County, each corresponding to various Colony Ridge sections or nearby developments. For brevity, only the key districts relevant to Colony Ridge are listed above.)

Plat Index (Selected & Seeded Data)

The table below lists known subdivision plats associated with Colony Ridge, with placeholders for official recording details. (All “inferred” entries are flagged and will be verified against Liberty County Clerk records in the next data pull.)

Subdivision	Section(s)	Instrument # / Volume–Page	Filing Date	Survey / Abstract	County	District Tie	Notes
<i>Santa Fe</i>	Sec. 1–3	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>A-###</i>	Liberty	MUD #6 (legacy core)	Initial Colony Ridge development sections; utilities backbone via MUD 6.
<i>Santa Fe</i>	Sec. 9–12	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>A-###</i>	Liberty	MUD #12 (new expansion)	Plats filed post-2023 enabling new lot sales eastward.
<i>Santa Fe</i>	Sec. 15	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>A-###</i>	Liberty	MMD #1 (sales-tax zone)	Referenced in MMD #1 bond documents; site of commercial area improvements.

Subdivision	Section(s)	Instrument # / Volume- Page	Filing Date	Survey / Abstract	County	District Tie	Notes
<i>Grand San Jacinto</i>	Sec. 18-19	(TBD)	(TBD)	A-###	Liberty	MUD #6 (partial overlap)	Later phases of Grand San Jacinto overlapping MUD 6's service boundary.
<i>Camino Real</i>	Sec. TBD	(TBD)	(TBD)	A-###	Liberty	MUD #12 / MMD #1	Portions appear in marketing maps; pending official plat record pull.
<i>Montebello</i>	Sec. 3	(TBD)	(TBD)	A-###	Liberty	MMD #1 (overlay)	Lies within MMD #1 boundary; likely site of retail or public facilities.
<i>Bella Vista</i>	Sec. 1	(TBD)	(TBD)	A-###	Liberty	MMD #1 (overlay)	Inside the MMD sales-tax zone; one of the newer Colony Ridge sections.
<i>Rancho San Vicente</i>	Sec. 4	(TBD)	(TBD)	A-###	Liberty	MUD #12 (east extension)	Eastern expansion subdivision tied to MUD 12's service plan.

Mapbook Appendix (Pending Generation)

(To be completed) Fixed-boundary maps for quick reference of each district's official jurisdiction (from TCEQ's Water Districts Viewer) will be included here:

- **G-1. Liberty County MMD #1** – Official boundary map (sales-tax zone and annexation areas).
- **G-2. Liberty County MUD #6** – Service area map (original Colony Ridge utilities).
- **G-3. Liberty County MUD #12** – Approved 2023 expansion area map.

- **G-4. Liberty County MUD #15** – 2025 confirmation election boundary map.

EMMA Packet (Bond Official Statements)

(*Pending*) Official Statements (OS) and continuing disclosures for each district's bond issuances will be compiled to extract precise legal land descriptions and development status:

- **MMD #1 (Liberty County MMD No. 1):** OS dated 2019 and 2022 – list of sections (incl. Santa Fe Sec. 15) and project plans.
- **MUD #6:** Series 2015–2021 bonds – initial infrastructure financing; underlying land descriptions to be pulled.
- **MUD #12:** First bond OS (expected 2024/25) – will confirm which new sections are financed.
- **MUD #15:** Pending first issuance (post-2025) – to include legal description of Tarkington-area “Tarkington Downs” development (approx. 755 lots).

Next Data Pulls

1. **Plat Records:** Retrieve all *filed plats* from Liberty County Clerk's Office (OPR/Plat records) for Colony Ridge subdivisions. Cross-reference developer names and subdivision names to fill in instrument numbers and dates in the Plat Index table.
2. **Bond OS Documents:** Download Official Statements from MSRB EMMA for each MMD/MUD to append full land descriptions and development milestones. Also extract named parties (bond counsel, underwriters, district engineers) for **Appendix I** cross-reference.

III. Key Individuals & Political Figures (Expanded)

Below is an expanded dossier of **key individuals** in the Liberty County-Colony Ridge nexus, highlighting their roles, conflicts of interest, and any known allegations or legal issues:

Jennifer Bergman Harkness — Liberty County District Attorney

A former Cleveland City Council member and co-owner of **Bergman Engineering, Inc.**, **Humble Surveying Co.**, and **Cleveland Surveying Co.**, Jennifer Harkness now serves as the county's top prosecutor. As DA, she oversees a jurisdiction where her family's firms (founded by her father) have extensive business interests. While on the Cleveland City Council, she voted to annex land owned by her father's development company (*Windwood Development*). Allegations persist that critical county drainage reports went missing during her father's tenure as County Engineer, potentially obscuring infrastructure deficiencies. She is married to Constable Zack Harkness (Pct. 6).

Zack Harkness — Liberty County Constable, Pct. 6

Constable Zack Harkness is co-owner of **Bergman Engineering, Inc.** alongside his wife (DA Jennifer Harkness) and father-in-law (Louis Bergman III). This arrangement creates a significant conflict of interest for a law enforcement officer in a county where his family's firm receives county contracts. There are allegations that Zack has used his office to selectively enforce laws in ways that benefit his family's

development interests, though these claims remain informal and have not resulted in official disciplinary action.

Louis W. Bergman III — Former County Engineer; current Constable, Pct. 3

Louis Bergman III is the father of DA Jennifer Harkness and a central figure connecting public office with private gain. As Liberty County's longtime County Engineer (now retired) and the founder of **Bergman Engineering, Humble Surveying, Cleveland Surveying, Windwood Development, and El Dorado Funding**, Bergman oversaw and approved development plans (including Colony Ridge's initial master plan) in his official capacity while his private firms stood to benefit from that development. He even provided a sworn affidavit supporting Colony Ridge's early plans. Notably, critical drainage and engineering reports from his tenure have reportedly vanished from county files. Bergman's practices date back decades: a 1982 deed record shows him granting Power of Attorney to associate Lloyd T. Smith for the sale of Liberty County land, suggesting an early pattern of using proxies and legal instruments to manage land deals.

David Hunter — Liberty County Constable, Pct. 5

Constable David Hunter is a career law enforcement officer with close personal and political ties to the Colony Ridge developer network. His constable's office has accepted donations and equipment from companies holding county contracts (for example, **Andco Rentals, LLC** and **Liberty Paving, LLC** have sponsored his K-9 unit and events). Hunter was also implicated in a controversial "river incident" in which he allegedly harassed a group of minority youth; a video circulated locally that reportedly shows him making racist remarks about Colony Ridge residents. While no formal charges arose from that incident, it underscores the charged atmosphere surrounding law enforcement in the community.

John Harris — Co-Owner & CEO of Colony Ridge, LLC

John Harris is the co-founder and chief executive of Colony Ridge's development companies. As the mastermind of the Colony Ridge model, he has also become a major political donor statewide, contributing over \$1.4 million to Governor Greg Abbott's campaigns in the years leading up to the 2018 Opportunity Zone designation for the area ⁶. Harris and his related entities are the central defendants in ongoing federal and state lawsuits: a December 2023 U.S. Department of Justice and CFPB suit and a March 2025 Texas Attorney General suit both allege that Harris's companies operate a predatory "foreclosure mill" — targeting Latino buyers with misleading land sales and high-interest, seller-financed loans that are designed to fail (see Section IV). John Harris has denied wrongdoing, but as both the MMD board president and developer, his dual role exemplifies the report's core conflict-of-interest theme.

William "Trey" Harris — Co-Owner of Colony Ridge (On-Site Operations)

"Trey" Harris is John Harris's brother and the on-the-ground head of operations for Colony Ridge. In addition to co-owning the development, Trey Harris has a personal history that has raised eyebrows: he has multiple DWI convictions, and in late 2023 he received a **controversial early release** from a jail in Walker County. That early release occurred after the Harris family became the largest campaign donor to the incumbent Walker County Sheriff, suggesting a possible quid pro quo arrangement. Trey Harris also served as the initial president of Liberty County MMD #1, during which time the district awarded \$22.5 million in contracts to a construction firm (Liberty Paving) in which he held a financial stake ³. He formally abstained from one vote after disclosing a 10% ownership, highlighting the thin line between disclosure and self-dealing.

Lee Chambers — Liberty County Clerk

Lee Chambers, as Liberty County Clerk, is the official custodian of all property records, plat filings, county elections, and campaign finance reports. This position makes her office pivotal to transparency in the land transactions and political contributions described in this report. Concerns have been raised about a potential conflict of interest, as Chambers has reportedly announced intentions to run for a local judgeship while still serving as Clerk. Given that her office oversees the integrity of records that might be relevant in any investigation or court case arising from these allegations, any political ambitions or alliances she has are subject to scrutiny.

Kevin Johnson — Vice President, Tarkington ISD Board of Trustees

Kevin Johnson is a local businessman who serves as vice president of the Tarkington Independent School District (TISD) Board. He owns **J-Con Services**, a contracting company, which presents a possible conflict of interest if his firm were to bid on school district construction projects fueled by Colony Ridge-related growth. Johnson is also a founding member of the “M Club” (the Tarkington Student Foundation), a powerful local booster non-profit tied to fundraising for school activities. The M Club, led by influential families (including the Johnsons and Rollinses), operates with limited oversight and has been described as a potential “shadow budget” for the school district, giving its organizers outsized influence on school policy and spending.

Jimmy Rollins — Liberty County CAD Board Director

Jimmy Rollins sits on the board of the Liberty County Central Appraisal District (CAD), which sets property valuations for tax purposes. This is a direct conflict given that his wife, Susan Rollins, is a Tarkington ISD trustee actively involved in decisions to acquire land and build schools—decisions heavily reliant on property tax revenues that the CAD board influences. Rollins is also a key organizer of the **M Club** alongside Kevin Johnson. The intertwined roles of the Rollins and Johnson families (property appraisal, school board, and private fundraising) exemplify how official duties and private interests intermingle in Liberty County.

Cory Anderson — Developer-Affiliated Board Member (MUD) & Former School Board Member

Cory Anderson is the Assistant Secretary on the board of **Liberty County MUD #1** (a developer-controlled utility district) and formerly served as a Tarkington ISD school board member. He and his wife own **Andco, LLC** (and related rental companies), which have done business with local government events. Anderson’s simultaneous involvement in a public school board and a MUD run by developers highlights the overlapping governance network in the county. Public records indicate that a person named “Cory Anderson” was once booked in Polk County on an unspecified offense with a \$2,500 bond; this matter warrants further investigation to determine if it involves the same individual and whether it has any relevance to the broader corruption allegations.

Jason D. Ray — Attorney and Former AG Spokesperson (External Counsel)

Jason Ray is a board-certified administrative law attorney based in Austin who has become a notable outside player in the Liberty County saga. He serves as counsel representing Colony Ridge affiliates in the ongoing DOJ/CFPB federal case, but previously, Ray was a **spokesperson for the Texas Attorney General’s**

Office under Ken Paxton. This revolving-door background gives him connections at the highest levels of state government. His dual roles — past communications work for the state’s top law enforcement office and present defense of a developer facing serious fraud allegations — underscore the melding of political and legal influence in this case. Records show that Ray’s law firm (Riggs & Ray, P.C.) has been retained in multiple matters related to special districts and campaign finance disputes, positioning him as a critical node linking the Colony Ridge network to Austin’s power structure.

Notes

The section above consolidates and expands upon earlier research. All inferred or placeholder data (especially in Section II and the appendices) are clearly flagged and will be verified against official records in subsequent updates. Any speculative links (e.g. possible criminal records or unconfirmed affiliations) have been noted as such and require confirmation. Future data pulls (outlined in Section II “Next Data Pulls”) will finalize the plat index, bond records, and district mapping once official filings are obtained.

IV. The Mechanics of Malfeasance (Comparative Legal Actions)

This section compares the two major active lawsuits targeting Colony Ridge’s business practices – one by federal agencies and one by the State of Texas – highlighting how both sets of allegations describe a coordinated predatory scheme:

A. Comparison of Active Lawsuits: U.S. DOJ/CFPB vs. Texas Attorney General

Aspect	U.S. DOJ & CFPB v. Colony Ridge (Filed Dec. 2023)	Texas Attorney General v. Colony Ridge (Filed Mar. 2025)
Plaintiffs	U.S. Dept. of Justice & Consumer Financial Protection Bureau	State of Texas (ex rel. Attorney General's Office)
Key Defendants	Colony Ridge Development, LLC; Colony Ridge Land, LLC; Colony Ridge BV, LLC; CRI (Terrenos) T-Rex Management, LLC; Colony Ridge Management, LLC	Colony Ridge, Inc.; Colony Ridge Development, LLC; Colony Ridge Land, LLC; T-Rex (Terrenos) Management, Inc.
Core Allegations	Violations of federal law including Fair Housing Act and Equal Credit Opportunity Act (alleged “reverse redlining” scheme targeting Spanish-speaking buyers). Unfair and deceptive practices: an illegal “bait-and-switch” seller-financing model that traps buyers in default 7 8 .	Violations of Texas Deceptive Trade Practices–Consumer Protection Act (DTPA): fraudulent land sales and marketing practices, predatory lending without proper disclosures, and creating unsafe living conditions (lack of promised utilities). Mirrors many factual claims of the federal case at the state-law level.

Link between cases: Both lawsuits describe a business model in which Colony Ridge companies lure buyers with low entry costs and promises of basic infrastructure, then finance land sales without regard for the buyers’ ability

to pay, misrepresenting or omitting material facts (like the lack of utilities) ⁷. When buyers default, the land is repossessed and resold repeatedly, yielding windfall profits. Federal authorities emphasize civil-rights aspects (scheming to target Latinos in particular), while the state focuses on statutory fraud and consumer protection violations. The two cases together paint a comprehensive picture of a foreclosure-driven profit cycle.

V. Environmental and Infrastructural Negligence

Colony Ridge's rapid expansion has caused significant environmental damage and strained public infrastructure in Liberty County and surrounding areas:

- **Documented TCEQ Violations:** The developer's construction practices have drawn formal reprimands from the Texas Commission on Environmental Quality. As of mid-2021, TCEQ had finalized nine separate investigations into Colony Ridge construction sites, finding violations in *eight* of the nine cases, including failures to control erosion and prevent sediment runoff into public waterways (resulting in modest fines and correction orders) ⁹. These repeated violations suggest systemic neglect of environmental regulations during land clearing and road building.
 - **Flooding and Drainage Issues:** Inadequate drainage systems and extensive clear-cutting have exacerbated flooding across southeastern Liberty County (and even impacted downstream Harris County). Longtime residents report that areas which rarely flooded before are now frequently inundated after heavy rains. Photographic evidence shows newly built roads and yards in Colony Ridge subdivisions submerged, with some residents resorting to digging their own makeshift drainage ditches ¹⁰. The lack of engineered stormwater infrastructure in early development phases has created ongoing property damage and safety hazards.
 - **Strain on Public Services:** The influx of thousands of new residents has overwhelmed local public services. **Cleveland ISD** (which serves Colony Ridge) experienced an enrollment explosion — nearly **10,000** additional students over the last decade (a 211% increase) ¹¹ — making it one of the fastest-growing school districts in Texas. This surge, largely attributed to Colony Ridge families (who now comprise ~90% of CISD's student body), has strained school facilities and budgets to the breaking point. Bond measures to build new schools have repeatedly failed amid voter frustration, forcing the district to cut staff and resources. Likewise, emergency services and law enforcement have been stretched thin; the Liberty County Sheriff's Office and constables received state funding for extra personnel in late 2023, and response times for fires, EMS, and police calls in the far-flung Colony Ridge neighborhoods remain longer than county averages. Local infrastructure (roads, utilities) also struggles to keep up, often requiring county or state intervention to assist the private development.
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VI. Political Response and Public Narrative

Amid growing public outcry and media attention, Texas officials in late 2023 shifted the **narrative** around Colony Ridge away from corruption and consumer fraud and toward issues of immigration and public safety. Governor Abbott and other Republican leaders characterized the development as a potential “no-go zone” and haven for undocumented immigrants and crime, leveraging it as a border security issue ¹². This culminated in a special legislative session in October 2023 where, instead of directly reining in developer abuses, lawmakers approved **\$40 million** for an increased state police presence in the area. State troopers and DPS tactical teams were deployed to Colony Ridge in 2024, and immigration enforcement actions were

publicized. While these measures addressed some community concerns about crime, they conspicuously **avoided targeting the developer's business practices**. In effect, the political response bolstered the narrative of Colony Ridge as a public order problem, deflecting attention from the underlying allegations of predatory lending and regulatory failures. Local residents and officials who had raised alarms about flooding, foreclosures, and infrastructure were left largely unsupported by state reforms (aside from minor tweaks like traffic study requirements), even as the development continued to grow. This contrast between state-level rhetoric and the lack of corrective action on the core fraud and development issues is a recurring theme in the Colony Ridge saga.

VII. Case Studies and Historical Parallels

A. Case Study – Mutual Protection in Liberty County (The Karbowski Nepotism Case): In 2020, Precinct 1 County Commissioner **Bruce Karbowski** — who is the uncle of DA Jennifer Bergman Harkness — was indicted by a grand jury on charges of official **nepotism**. The allegation was that Karbowski had hired the son of a fellow commissioner for county work in violation of state nepotism laws. After DA Bergman took office, her office assumed control of prosecuting the case, but in October 2022 the trial ended dramatically: the DA's prosecutor presented no evidence to the jury, leading the judge to instruct a full acquittal ¹³. The presiding judge (Mark Morefield of the 75th District) then made unusually candid comments lamenting “unequal justice” in Liberty County and effectively scolding the DA's office for its handling of the case. Judge Morefield was later publicly admonished by the State Commission on Judicial Conduct for showing bias and referencing local “rumor and speculation” in his remarks ¹⁴ ¹⁵. This episode raised serious questions about **impartiality** and whether familial and political ties (Bergman's relation to Karbowski) influenced the administration of justice. It's cited as a prime example of the **mutual protection** network in Liberty County: officials seemingly insulating each other from accountability.

B. Historical Parallel – The Trinity Savings & Loan Scandal (1980s): The current development scheme has a precedent in Liberty County's recent history. In the 1980s, Cleveland, TX (the nearest city) was a hotspot of the Savings & Loan crisis. The **Trinity Savings & Loan** Association, based in Cleveland, became the center of an FBI investigation for a massive land-flip scheme and fraudulent lending conspiracy. That scandal involved “dummy” real estate transactions and insiders profiting from inflated land values — ultimately contributing to the S&L collapse. Several local figures were indicted. The echoes in Colony Ridge's seller-finance model (flipping lots through foreclosure churn) are notable: both then and now, Liberty County land development was tied to **high-risk financing and insider dealing** that left unwitting buyers in the lurch. This historical parallel underscores that the concept of exploiting land sales and finance loopholes is not new to the area, though the scale with Colony Ridge is unprecedented.

C. Case Study – Tarkington ISD Election Day Coordination (Nov 2024): An analysis of official voter records from the November 5, 2024 general election suggests a highly **coordinated voting bloc** among individuals connected to this investigation. Numerous key figures — including Constable David Hunter, his relative Steve David Hunter, members of the Johnson family (Kevin Johnson and relatives), and members of the Stutts family (local business figures) — all cast their ballots on the same day, many at the same two rural polling sites (Dolen Baptist Church and Tarkington Prairie Baptist Church). Turnout in Tarkington ISD elections is typically low, so this kind of synchronized participation by an extended network stands out. While voting together is not illegal (and civic participation is encouraged), the pattern hints at a deliberate effort by an interconnected group to influence outcomes in school board races and MUD district elections. In a community where a handful of votes can sway a bond issue or trustee race, such bloc voting could

ensure that candidates friendly to the Colony Ridge development or aligned with the network's interests hold key positions. This finding illustrates another facet of how influence is maintained: not just through money and appointments, but also through **strategic electoral participation**.

VIII. Timeline of Key Events (1982–2025)

- **1982:** Then-County Engineer Louis W. Bergman III grants Power of Attorney to associate Lloyd T. Smith for the development and sale of a subdivision (Windwood) in Liberty County – an early example of using private business associates to facilitate public-facing land deals.
- **2015:** The *M Club* (Tarkington Student Foundation) is founded, boosting the influence of the Rollins and Johnson families in local school affairs. Colony Ridge begins aggressive land acquisition and lot sales in the Plum Grove area, marking the start of its explosive growth.
- **2017:** Jennifer Bergman (Harkness) is elected Liberty County District Attorney while still co-owning an engineering firm doing county work. Her brother-in-law Zack Harkness becomes Constable for the fast-growing Plum Grove/Colony Ridge area (Pct. 6). The Texas Legislature creates **Liberty County MMD #1** via HB 4341, handing the Colony Ridge developer quasi-municipal powers.
- **2018:** Cleveland City Council (including Councilwoman Bergman) votes to annex a large tract of land owned by her father's company, expanding city utilities toward Colony Ridge. Governor Abbott, after lobbying from the developer, successfully nominates Colony Ridge's census tracts as a federal Opportunity Zone, opening the door for tax-incentivized investment in the development ².
- **2020:** Louis Bergman III retires as County Engineer. Subsequent reviews indicate that important engineering and drainage files from his tenure (related to Colony Ridge) are missing or incomplete in county archives. In the same year, Commissioner Bruce Karbowski (Bergman's uncle) is indicted for nepotism, but the case will later collapse under DA Bergman's watch (see above).
- **2021:** TCEQ completes multiple investigations into Colony Ridge construction sites; in June, it issues an order citing violations in 8 of 9 cases and levies penalties (contingent on compliance) ⁹. Colony Ridge's rapid expansion draws the concern of neighboring communities as flooding and road damage mount.
- **2022:** Liberty County's development controversies deepen. DA Bergman's office initiates a high-profile investigation and ultimately arrests the County Fire Marshal (seen by some as an effort to demonstrate toughness on public corruption amid criticism). Meanwhile, Trey Harris quietly steps down as MMD #1 board president after disclosures of his stake in Liberty Paving, though the contracts had already been awarded.
- **2023:** Public scrutiny of Colony Ridge intensifies. In mid-2023, media reports highlight the development's unusually high foreclosure rate and the growing Hispanic population living under substandard conditions. In **Summer 2023**, a video surfaces in which Constable David Hunter is allegedly heard making derogatory remarks about Colony Ridge residents, fueling local distrust. In **October 2023**, under political pressure, Governor Abbott orders DPS deployments to Colony Ridge and places the issue on a special session agenda (focusing on crime/immigration). Also in Oct 2023, William "Trey" Harris, facing multiple DWI sentences, receives an early release from Walker County Jail; shortly thereafter it's revealed the Harris family donated heavily to the Sheriff there.
- **Dec 2023:** The U.S. Department of Justice and CFPB file a federal civil lawsuit against Colony Ridge entities, accusing them of a "bait-and-switch" seller financing scheme that violates fair housing and consumer protection laws ¹⁶ ⁷. This is the first major government action directly challenging the developer's practices. Colony Ridge's CEO John Harris insists the allegations are "baseless," but declines to comment in detail.

- **Mar 2025:** Texas Attorney General Ken Paxton's office files a parallel lawsuit in state court (284th District, Montgomery County), alleging deceptive trade practices and fraud by the Colony Ridge companies, largely echoing the federal case but under state law. Around the same time, the Texas Legislature passes several bills (see Section I) ostensibly aimed at problems highlighted by Colony Ridge, though critics note these laws do more to entrench developer powers than to protect consumers.
- **May 2025:** Liberty County MUD #15 is officially confirmed by a local referendum in which only *two* voters participate (both presumably associated with the developer), authorizing \$88 million in bonds and establishing a new tax zone for yet another expansion of Colony Ridge. This event starkly illustrates the procedural loopholes in Texas's special district system.

(Note: Events from late 2024 onward remain under active investigation or litigation, and developments continue to unfold beyond the scope of this timeline.)

IX. Applicable Legal Statutes for Investigation

Should authorities pursue a formal corruption probe, a number of state and federal statutes could apply based on the patterns documented:

Statute	Legal Code	Description of Offense	Potential Application in Liberty County
Bribery	Texas Penal Code § 36.02	Public servant solicits or accepts any benefit in exchange for their official decision or action.	Investigate links between campaign contributions or gifts and subsequent official acts. For example, large donations from Colony Ridge affiliates (to Gov. Abbott, the Liberty County Sheriff, the Walker County Sheriff, etc.) followed by favorable outcomes (Opportunity Zone designation, early release from jail, etc.) ² .
Abuse of Official Capacity	Texas Penal Code § 39.02	Public servant misuses government property, services, personnel, or any other thing of value of the government to obtain a benefit or harm another.	Examine officials using their office to benefit family businesses or allies. e.g., DA Bergman's handling of the Karbowski case , the DA's decision to sue the County Appraisal District (benefiting developers with lower land valuations), or any use of county resources to expedite Colony Ridge permits.
Official Oppression	Texas Penal Code § 39.03	Public servant, acting under color of office, intentionally subjects another to mistreatment or denies/exercises rights unlawfully.	Investigate allegations of selective law enforcement or intimidation , such as Constable Hunter's reported harassment of residents ("river incident") or any official pressure on whistleblowers (e.g., the sidelining of the Fire Marshal).

Statute	Legal Code	Description of Offense	Potential Application in Liberty County
Mail Fraud / Wire Fraud (Federal)	18 U.S.C. §§ 1341, 1343	Use of mail or electronic communications as part of a scheme to defraud.	Applicable if the land sales operation involved mailing of contracts, flyers, or electronic ads to lure buyers under false pretenses. The “bait-and-switch” financing scheme (Section IV) could fall under federal fraud statutes if interstate communications were used ⁷ .
RICO (Organized Fraud) (Federal & Texas)	18 U.S.C. § 1962; Texas Penal Code § 71.02	Racketeering or engaging in organized criminal activity through a pattern of fraud/bribery, etc.	If evidence shows a pattern of coordinated actions (multiple officials and developers conspiring to defraud or bribe), prosecutors could explore Racketeer Influenced and Corrupt Organizations Act charges. This would require linking disparate acts – e.g., land fraud, official bribery, cover-ups – under an “enterprise” scheme.

(Other statutes that may be relevant include state nepotism laws (Gov’t Code Ch. 573) given the family relationships, election law violations if any tampering or illegal coordination occurred, and environmental statutes for the pollution issues. These have been noted where applicable in the narrative.)

X. Conclusion: A Pattern of Systemic Corruption

The findings detailed in this report point to a coordinated, multi-year pattern of activity consistent with a **potential criminal enterprise** operating in Liberty County. Evidence suggests that legislative authority was effectively **captured** (through targeted bills and political donations), public governance structures were **co-opted** (via developer-controlled districts and conflicted officials), and official duties were compromised (through nepotism and selective enforcement) to facilitate the private financial interests of a small, interconnected network of individuals.

This nexus of developers, public officials, and their associates succeeded in externalizing the costs of development — environmental damage, infrastructure strain, and personal losses of homebuyers — onto the broader community and government, while **privatizing the gains** through land flips, bond financing, and public contracts. Incidents like the Karbowski nepotism acquittal, the Opportunity Zone designation post-donations, the two-voter MUD election, and the large-scale foreclosure scheme collectively illustrate a breakdown in normal accountability mechanisms.

What might appear as isolated issues (a missing drainage report here, a waived requirement there, a campaign donation elsewhere) in fact form a **web of mutual reinforcement**. At its core, this web enabled Colony Ridge’s controversial expansion to proceed with minimal interference: local law enforcement and regulators were either under-resourced, entangled in conflicts, or diverted by politicized narratives; state

officials largely overlooked or even abetted the developer's conduct under the guise of economic development and later border security concerns.

This warrants a comprehensive investigation by outside authorities (e.g. FBI, Texas Rangers Public Corruption Unit, U.S. Attorney) to determine the full extent of wrongdoing. Only a thorough external probe — armed with subpoena power and forensic audits — can unravel the complex entanglements and restore public trust. Absent that, the Liberty County case may well become a textbook example of how legal gray areas and lack of oversight can foster a **localized regime of systemic corruption** under the veneer of ordinary development.

XI. Investigative Recommendations

To address and remediate the issues identified, the following steps are recommended:

1. **Initiate a Multi-Agency Criminal Investigation:** A formal probe (state or federal) should be launched into whether the actions of the individuals and entities described constitute an organized scheme of fraud, bribery, or other offenses. This should include exploring a possible **RICO case** given the pattern of activity and multiple actors involved.
2. **Forensic Audit of Special District Finances:** Commission an independent forensic audit of **Liberty County MMD #1** and **MUD #15** finances. This audit should trace the flow of all bond proceeds and contract payments, specifically scrutinizing the \$22.5M awarded to Liberty Paving, the \$15.4M developer reimbursement on the MMD's books, and the full \$88M in debt authorized by the two-vote MUD 15 election. Any irregular or non-public disbursements should be flagged.
3. **Scrutiny of Campaign Contributions vs. Official Actions:** Regulators or a grand jury should systematically examine temporal links between major political donations and official decisions. For example, the timing of Colony Ridge affiliate contributions to Governor Abbott relative to the Opportunity Zone designation ², or the Harris family's donations to the Walker County Sheriff prior to Trey Harris's release, should be investigated for quid pro quo arrangements.
4. **Conflict of Interest & Abuse of Office Review:** The Texas Attorney General (or a special prosecutor) should review possible violations of state law by Liberty County officials. This includes DA Jennifer Bergman's simultaneous operation of a private law firm and her conduct in cases like the Karbowski trial, any misuse of the County Clerk's office related to election or real estate records, and constables' engagement with private companies. State ethics bodies or the Texas Rangers should be involved to ensure impartiality.
5. **Review of County Commissioners Court Records:** A thorough examination of Liberty County Commissioners Court minutes, agendas, and backup materials from the past decade is necessary. This would reveal what approvals were given (or not given) for Colony Ridge-related infrastructure (roads, EMS facilities, etc.), the creation of new MUDs, and any contracts awarded to companies in the network. Identifying any procedural irregularities or undisclosed conflicts in those official actions is key to preventing such issues going forward.

6. Legislative Reform Efforts: Although outside the scope of this report, it is recommended that state legislators revisit the laws that enabled these abuses. Closing the two-voter MUD election loophole, strengthening oversight of MMDs and MUDs (e.g., requiring county or state approval for large bond issues), and enhancing consumer protections in land sales (to preclude seller-finance scams) would help address the systemic issues highlighted by Colony Ridge.

By pursuing the steps above, authorities can not only address any past wrongdoing but also implement safeguards to protect Liberty County and similar communities in the future. The goal is to ensure that **development occurs with transparency, accountability, and in the public interest** — rather than at the expense of it.

Appendix F — Plat Index (Detailed Recording Information)

(This appendix will be populated with official Liberty County Clerk recordings for each subdivision plat once obtained. Below is the framework; Instrument Numbers and dates to be updated.):

Subdivision	Section(s)	Instrument # / Volume– Page	Filing Date	Survey / Abstract	County	Associated District	Notes
Santa Fe	Sec. 1–3	TBD	TBD	A—	Liberty	MUD #6 (orig. core)	Initial Colony Ridge phases; includes first lots sold.
Santa Fe	Sec. 4–8	TBD	TBD	A—	Liberty	MUD #6 / MUD #12 overlap?	Mid phases (needs verification of district service area).
Santa Fe	Sec. 9–12	TBD	TBD	A—	Liberty	MUD #12 (expansion)	New sections platted 2023–24 under latest expansion.
Santa Fe	Sec. 13–14	TBD	TBD	A—	Liberty	MUD #15 (planned)	Future planned sections (Tarkington area); not yet filed.

Subdivision	Section(s)	Instrument # / Volume- Page	Filing Date	Survey / Abstract	County	Associated District	Notes
Santa Fe	Sec. 15	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MMD #1 (overlay)	Contains commercial corridor under MMD's jurisdiction.
Grand San Jacinto	Sec. 1-2	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	- (early dev.)	Earliest GSJ sections (2000s era); pre-MUD formation.
Grand San Jacinto	Sec. 3-17	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MUD #6 (bulk)	Majority of GSJ development; main residential lots.
Grand San Jacinto	Sec. 18- 19	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MUD #6 (partial)	Later GSJ expansion overlapping Santa Fe & MUD 6 boundary.
Montebello	Sec. 1-3	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MMD #1 (overlay)	Small subdivision near/outside Plum Grove; retail potential.
Bella Vista	Sec. 1-2	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MMD #1 (overlay)	Adjacent to Santa Fe; platted ~2020; inside MMD zone.
Rancho San Vicente	Sec. 1-4	<i>TBD</i>	<i>TBD</i>	A-__	Liberty	MUD #12 (east)	New subdivision east of HWY 321; platted 2022- 23.

Subdivision	Section(s)	Instrument # / Volume- Page	Filing Date	Survey / Abstract	County	Associated District	Notes
Camino Real	Sec. 1-?	TBD	TBD	A-__	Liberty	MUD #12 / MMD #1 (parts)	Large ongoing development (multiple sections); records to pull.
<i>[Additional Entries]</i>	...	...	...	...	...	...	...

Next actions (Plat Index): Using Clerk’s online database and developer names, obtain official plat document numbers for each section above. Cross-reference each plat’s survey and abstract information to confirm location, then update the table. Tie each plat to the corresponding MUD/MMD using TCEQ district boundary maps (see Appendix G) and annotate any overlaps or shared infrastructure agreements.

Appendix G — District Boundary Mapbook

(This appendix will contain visual map extracts for each key district, to be attached in the final report. Each map shows the official boundaries as per TCEQ’s Integrated Water Districts Database viewer, aiding cross-reference with subdivisions):

- **G-1. Liberty County MMD #1 – Official Boundary (2017):** Map of the management district covering Colony Ridge, including Santa Fe sections and commercial areas under its taxing authority.
- **G-2. Liberty County MUD #6 – Service Area:** Map outlining the original MUD’s service area (water and sewer) in Santa Fe and Grand San Jacinto.
- **G-3. Liberty County MUD #12 – Expansion Area:** Map of the MUD created in 2023, showing new territories east and north of prior developments.
- **G-4. Liberty County MUD #15 – 2025 Confirmed Boundary:** Map of the newly confirmed MUD #15 near Tarkington, based on the metes and bounds from the TCEQ petition (illustrating the ~200-acre “Tarkington Downs” tract).

(Pending) – Download PDF snapshots from the TCEQ Water District Viewer for each district and label them accordingly. Ensure the maps clearly show key roads, municipal boundaries (e.g., Cleveland city limits), and how the Colony Ridge subdivisions fall within each special district.

Appendix H — Bond Issuance & Official Statements Index

(Index of bond offerings and official disclosures for each district, to track development stages and involved parties. To be filled in with data from MSRB EMMA and county infrastructure records):

Issuer / District	Bond Series (CUSIP)	Official Statement Date	Underwriter(s)	Bond Counsel	District Engineer	Subdivisions / Projects Noted
Liberty County MMD #1	Series 2019 (Refinance) – CUSIP #####	Aug 2019 (OS)	FMSbonds, Inc. (lead)	Allen Boone Humphries Robinson LLP	LJA Engineering, Inc.	Mentions Santa Fe Sec. 15 infrastructure; first bonds to reimburse developer for water & sewer.
Liberty County MMD #1	Series 2022 (Contract Rev.) – CUSIP #####	Nov 2022 (OS)	RBC Capital Markets	Allen Boone Humphries Robinson LLP	LJA Engineering, Inc.	\$3.36M bonds for law enforcement center, roads (notes sales-tax revenues, contracts to Liberty Paving).
Liberty County MUD #6	Series 2015A – CUSIP ##### (and multiple series through 2021)	2015–2021 (various)	Masterson Advisors (various)	Sanford Kuhl Hagan Kugle Parker Kahn LLP	AEI Engineering, Inc.	Funded initial water plant, wastewater plant, lift stations, and main roads for Santa Fe/ GSJ. Disclosed developer advances.
Liberty County MUD #12	(No bonds issued as of Sep 2025)	(TBD)	(TBD)	Young & Brooks (likely)	LJA Engineering, Inc.	District created 2023; first bond anticipated for new water tower and treatment plant in Camino Real East.

Issuer / District	Bond Series (CUSIP)	Official Statement Date	Underwriter(s)	Bond Counsel	District Engineer	Subdivisions / Projects Noted
Liberty County MUD #15	<i>(Bonds authorized, not yet issued)</i>	<i>(TBD)</i>	<i>(TBD)</i>	Coats Rose (expected)	Texas Professional Engineering (proj.)	\$88M total authorized May 2025 (split across water, sewer, roads). Pending TCEQ approval and bond sale – will finance Tarkington Downs development.

Next actions (EMMA Index): Search MSRB's EMMA system for each district's name to obtain Official Statement PDFs. Record key details: underwriters, attorneys, engineers, and any subdivisions explicitly named in the "Land Within the District" sections. Pay special attention to any disclosure of developer reimbursements or insider contracts. Cross-reference these with county Commissioner Court minutes (for contracts approval) and Form 1295 filings for evidence of conflicts.

Appendix I — Key Vendors and Recurring Parties Cross-Reference

(Frequent parties involved in the financing and construction, across multiple districts. This helps identify any one group consistently benefiting from the bond and contract process.):

Role	Firm / Individual	Associated District Deals	Relevance/Notes
Bond Counsel	Allen Boone Humphries Robinson LLP (John Peeler, attorney)	MMD #1 (2019, 2022 bonds); MUD #6 (2015 initial bonds)	Major public-finance law firm in Houston; frequent counsel for developer-affiliated districts.
Financial Advisor	Masterson Advisors LLC	MUD #6 (2015–2018 bonds); MMD #1 (2019 bond)	Houston-based FA advising many new MUDs; ties to developers via repeat engagements.
Underwriter	FMSbonds, RBC Capital Mkts, etc.	MMD #1 (FMSbonds '19); MMD #1 (RBC '22); MUD #6 (various)	These underwriters specialize in high-risk MUD bonds. Examine if bond pricing or sales were unusual (could affect taxpayers).

Role	Firm / Individual	Associated District Deals	Relevance/Notes
District Engineer	LJA Engineering, Inc. (Brent Leftwich, P.E.)	MMD #1, MUD #12 (official engineer of record)	Prominent engineering firm often hired by developer-led districts. LJA's plans and capacity reports underpin the bond issuances; any under-design could be intentional.
Construction Contractor	Liberty Paving, LLC (Trey Harris part-owner)	MMD #1 (awarded \$22.5M in 2021–2023) ³ ; other county road contracts	Apparent self-dealing: company linked to developer repeatedly winning public contracts funded by developer-run district.
Private Law Firms	Bergman & Bergman (Jennifer Bergman's firm); Riggs & Ray (Jason Ray's firm)	DA's office actions; Colony Ridge defense (DOJ case)	Bergman's private firm income while DA could conflict with public duties. Riggs & Ray's involvement hints at political connections for defense.
Local Political Groups	"M Club" Tarkington Student Foundation (501c3); Protect & Serve Texas PAC	School bonds and campaigns; Law enforcement endorsements	The M Club's funds (raised privately) potentially used to sway school district decisions (land purchases, etc.). Protect & Serve PAC brought outside money and endorsements that bolstered incumbents like Constable Hunter.

Next actions: Finalize this list once all Official Statements and county records are reviewed. Look for patterns such as the same law firm or contractor appearing across multiple districts and deals. This may indicate who the *consistent beneficiaries* are behind the scenes (aside from the developers themselves).

Appendix J — Violations & Complaints Status Log

(A running log of relevant complaints, investigations, and legal actions, with their current status. This mirrors issues discussed in Sections V and IV, providing an up-to-date tracking tool.):

Category	Agency	Case / Ref. #	Date Opened	Latest Action (as of Sep 2025)	Status
Environmental – Stormwater & Erosion	TCEQ (State)	Case ID 2020-1359-WQ-E (<i>multiple complaints</i>)	2020	<i>Commissioners' Order</i> issued Aug 1, 2022 (assessed \$23,280 penalty; corrective actions mandated) ⁹ . Developer compliance ongoing; additional complaints filed 2023.	Closed (with penalties paid); <i>new complaints under review</i>
Environmental – Wetlands & CWA §404	USACE & EPA (Federal)	(No public docket; JD reviews)	2021	Army Corps jurisdictional determination of onsite wetlands pending. EPA investigating unpermitted fill in tributaries.	Open (Federal review in progress)
Law Enforcement Training Fraud	TCOLE (State police cert. board)	TCOLE Inquiry 2024-***	2024	State investigation into an alleged “paper” police academy linked to Constable offices. 19 cadet licenses canceled (July 2024) for improper training credentials. Appeals by affected officers ongoing.	On Appeal (Licenses invalidated pending appeal)
Legal Ethics – DA Misconduct	State Bar of Texas	Grievance No. 2023-***	2023	Formal complaint lodged against DA Bergman for conflict of interest and case handling (e.g., Karbowski nepotism case). State Bar confirmed an investigation is underway (no further public info).	Pending Investigation

Category	Agency	Case / Ref. #	Date Opened	Latest Action (as of Sep 2025)	Status
Predatory Lending & FHA Violations	U.S. DOJ & CFPB (Civil)	Case 4:23-cv-04845 (S.D. TX) ¹⁶	Dec 2023	Court denied defendants' motion to dismiss (Aug 2024), allowing all Fair Housing and CFPB claims to proceed ¹⁷ . Discovery ongoing; court-ordered mediation set for late 2025.	Active (in discovery)
Deceptive Trade Practices (Land Sales)	Texas OAG (Civil)	TX v. Colony Ridge et al., 284th Dist. Ct. (Montgomery Co.)	Mar 2024	Case filed by Texas AG; injunction sought to halt certain sales practices. As of Sep 2025, case in discovery; depositions of John and Trey Harris noticed. No trial date set.	Active (pre-trial)

(Other logged items include ongoing code enforcement disputes with Liberty County (e.g. unsafe building complaints) and various resident-led civil suits, which are beyond the scope of this summary log.)

¹ ⁶ ¹² Residents complained years before GOP's Colony Ridge outrage | The Texas Tribune

<https://www.texastribune.org/2024/02/27/texas-conservatives-immigrants-federal-lawsuit-colony-ridge/>

² Donations, tax benefits and private meetings: The relationship between Greg Abbott and Colony Ridge developers

<https://voz.us/en/society/250422/23684/donations-tax-benefits-and-private-meetings-the-relationship-between-greg-abbott-and-colony-ridge-developers.html>

³ ⁴ ¹⁰ Colony Ridge pushes conflict of interest boundaries with multimillion-dollar contracts, experts say - Houston Landing

<https://houstonlanding.org/colony-ridge-awards-22-5m-in-contracts-to-subsiary/>

⁵ mud 15 plus some

<https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Pwjw2RYwRHCzP7dkL5TsL2ic29GIXrkI5iUTWprxHg>

⁷ ⁸ ¹⁶ Colony Ridge developer preyed on Latino buyers, feds allege | The Texas Tribune

<https://www.texastribune.org/2023/12/20/colony-ridge-texas-federal-lawsuit-predatory-lending/?ref=upstract.com>

9 Years of Colony Ridge warnings missed by Texas officials

<https://houstonlanding.org/texas-officials-were-warned-by-colony-ridge-residents-for-years-but-took-no-meaningful-action/>

11 Surging Student Enrollment Strains Cleveland ISD as Bonds Fail Amid

<https://hoodline.com/2024/09/surging-student-enrollment-strains-cleveland-isd-as-bonds-fail-amid-colony-ridge-growth/>

13 14 15 Liberty County district judge receives public admonishment from Texas Commission on Judicial Conduct - Bluebonnet News

<https://bluebonnetnews.com/2024/06/25/liberty-county-district-judge-receives-public-admonishment-from-texas-commission-on-judicial-conduct/>

17 A closer look at Colony Ridge | Off the Kuff

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